Pyramid' philosophy. He had returned to India with a desire to build a culture of 'social entrepreneurship', to reach out to those poor and marginalized sections who needed access to markets and technology. His NGO-like approach to politics appeared to mirror Rahul Gandhi's 'two Indias' philosophy.

Interestingly, during this period, Rahul Gandhi also sought out prominent left-leaning academics as part of his 'political learning' process. Professor Sudha Pai of Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU), an expert on BSP and UP politics, was one such academic. Rahul even attended a seminar at JNU on 'UP in the 1990s: Critical Perspectives on Politics, Society and Economy' and invited Prof. Pai to speak to a Congress youth training camp in Chitrakoot in UP. Dalit Bahujan scholar Kancha Ilaiah, known for his controversial anti-Brahminical views, was also engaged with. Caste politics in particular had, it seems, captured Rahul's imagination.

Gandhi clearly was looking for intellectual sustenance to shore up dwindling political self-confidence. One academic told me that Rahul would often ask him to suggest books he should be reading. 'When I gave him a list, he promptly asked his assistant to get the books as soon as possible,' the academic claims.

Another academic wooed by Rahul was Prof. Yogendra Yadav of CSDS, best known for his psephology and election analysis on television. 'I was most impressed with Rahul when I first met him,' Yogendra confessed to me once. 'He came across as good-hearted and well read.' Then why did Yogendra eventually not bite the bait and become part of Rahul's think tank? 'I think one eventually realized that for all his good intentions, he couldn't really change the system as he was promising. The Congress party was too set in its ways to change,' says Yogendra, who in 2013 joined the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP).

Yogendra may have stayed away, but Rahul appeared to find an intellectual mentor in Dr Mohan Gopal, director at the Rajiv Gandhi Institute of Contemporary Studies (RGICS) and a former director at the National Law School in Bangalore. Gopal joined RGICS in 2011 and began providing Rahul with key inputs on political and constitutional issues. It is